

PHILIP P ARNOLD, SANDRA BIGTREE, AND ADAM DJ BRETT

A PREFACE TO CHALLENGING THE JUSTIFICATIONS OF DOMINATION THROUGH RELIGION: “WE WERE PLANTING CORN, AND THEY WERE PLANTING CROSSES”

Abstract

This preface critically interrogates the theological and ritual justifications of domination embedded within eurochristian frameworks, as imposed through colonial encounters from 1492 onward. Centering the epistemological clash between eurochristian and Indigenous worldviews, it contrasts a distant, property-centered metaphysics with Haudenosaunee understandings of sacrality rooted in a reciprocal relationship to the land. Drawing on citations from Indigenous leaders and scholars, the text addresses the ongoing impacts of doctrines like the Doctrine of Discovery and legal decisions such as *Johnson v. M’Intosh*. It highlights healing movements such as #Landback and #Lakeback as ceremonial acts of restoring right relationship with land, sovereignty, and all living beings. Ultimately, the piece calls for a fundamental value change—one grounded in Indigenous knowledge—to dismantle systems of domination and promote planetary healing.

Keywords: *Religious studies, critical Indigenous Studies, decolonial studies*

PHILIP P. ARNOLD, SANDRA BIGTREE, AND ADAM DJ BRETT

A PREFACE TO CHALLENGING THE JUSTIFICATIONS OF DOMINATION THROUGH RELIGION: "WE WERE PLANTING CORN, AND THEY WERE PLANTING CROSSES"

Introduction

When people think of 1492 as the inciting moment of colonization, they often imagine the view from the conquistador's boat, suited up in armor, looking towards a vast and verdant shoreline where the Indigenous original inhabitants of Turtle Island may also be standing. Shawnee/Lenape scholar Steven T. Newcomb invites us to consider what the view from the shore was.¹ What did the original inhabitants who were enjoying their free prior existence see as they saw the ships coming towards them? One way of seeing this moment of encounter is as an epistemological clash of values. Onondaga Nation Turtle Clan Faithkeeper Oren Lyons remarks on the moment of encounter, saying, "We were planting corn, and they were planting crosses."² Patricia Seed and Philip P. Arnold help us to understand this clash of values as being instantiated not only through discursive regimes of power/knowledge but also through ritual actions.³ These ritual actions provide a theological and jurisprudential framework for the naturalization of the eurochristian worldview as normative.⁴

¹ Steven Newcomb, "The Challenges of Revoking the Papal Bulls: A View-from-the-Shore Analysis of Recent Statements by Christian Churches," *Cross Currents* (New York) 74, no. 4 (2024): 431–57, ProQuest Central (3223969695)..

² Philip P. Arnold et al., "Introduction to 200 Years of Johnson v. M'Intosh: Law, Religion, and Native American Lands," Peer Reviewed, *Canopy Forum*, March 10, 2023, <https://canopyforum.org/2023/03/10/introduction-to-the-200-years-of-johnson-v-mintosh-law-religion-and-native-american-lands-series/>.

³ Patricia Seed, *Ceremonies of Possession in Europe's Conquest of the New World, 1492 - 1640*, Reprinted (Cambridge University Press, 1998); Philip P. Arnold, *The Urgency of Indigenous Values*, Haudenosaunee and Indigenous Worlds (Syracuse University Press, 2023).

⁴ Here we use eurochristian in lowercase as the primary identifier for what could also be called white Christian Supremacy. Following Tink Tinker (wazhazhe, Osage Nation) and Roger Green we agree that eurochristian is a more accurate frame because it situates the hegemonic worldview within its locative religious and historical context Roger K. Green, "Neoliberalism and EuroChristianity," *Religions* 12, no. 9 (2021), <https://doi.org/10.3390/rel12090688>; George E. Tinker and Roger Green, "'eurochristian', Or What Are We Going To Do With White People - Revisited Part 1," Blog, *New Polis*, February 16, 2023, <https://thenewpolis.com/2023/02/16/eurochristian-or-what-are-we-going-to-do-with-white-people-revisited-tink-tinker-and-roger-green-part-1/>; George E. Tinker and Roger Green, "'eurochristian', Or What Are We Going To Do With White People - Revisited Part 2," Blog, *New Polis*, March 1, 2023, <https://thenewpolis.com/2023/03/01/eurochristian-or-what-are-we-going-to-do-with-white-people-revisited-tink-tinker-and-roger-green-part-2/>; George E. Tinker and Roger Green, "'eurochristian', Or What Are We Going To Do With White People - Revisited Part 3," Blog, *New Polis*, March 17, 2023, <https://thenewpolis.com/2023/03/17/eurochristian-or-what-are-we-going-to-do-with-white-people-revisited-tink-tinker-and-roger-green-part-3/>; George E. Tinker and Roger Green, "'eurochristian', Or What Are We Going To Do With White People - Revisited Part 4," Blog, *New Polis*, April 9, 2023, <https://thenewpolis.com/2023/04/09/eurochristian-or-what-are-we-going-to-do-with-white-people-revisited-tink-tinker-and-roger-green-part-4/>.. Likewise as our colleague Scott Manning Stevens (Akwesasne Mohawk) highlights in the fifteenth century when the papal bulls were being written race was not yet a dominant category S. M. Stevens, "On Early Modern Critical Race Studies and Critical Indigenous Studies: A Tri-Interview," in *Seeing Race Before Race: Visual*

Fundamental to this epistemological clash are the interlocking questions of what the sacred is and where it is located. On the one hand is the eurochristian model of the *Deus Otiosus*, who must be appeased through the acquisition of souls and territory.⁵ Here, the sacred itself could not be further removed from the lived materiality of existence. This model is in stark contradistinction to the Indigenous values of the Haudenosaunee worldview, which sees Mother Earth as a relative, not a resource.⁶ Within the Haudenosaunee view, human beings are not in a position of greater elevation than any other living beings. We are all responsible for one another. While the Taíno were performing ceremonies and fulfilling their responsibilities to the natural world, Christopher Columbus and his colonial force were conducting a ceremony of dispossession, seeking conquest on the material and metaphysical planes of existence. Such is the fundamental difference between the sacred found in the material world versus a sacredness that is distant and disinterested.

Theorizing Domination

Here in *Challenging the Justifications of Domination through Religion*, the first of two journal issues, you will find essays reflecting on the religious, international, and pedagogical dimensions of domination, hegemony, and oppression.⁷ The Domination Code, which Newcomb points towards, has an international valence and impacts not

Culture and the Racial Matrix in the Premodern World, ed. N. Ndiaye and L. Markey (ACMRS Press, 2023), <https://asu.pressbooks.pub/seeing-race-before-race/back-matter/on-critical-indigenous-studies-and-early-modern-critical-race-studies-a-tri-interview/>.. For these reasons we use the nonstandard yet hopefully precise term eurochristian.

⁵ Arnold, *The Urgency of Indigenous Values*, 257.

⁶ The founder of the American Indian Law Alliance (AILA), Tonya Gonnella Frichner, (Onondaga Nation, Snipe Clan) would always say Mother Earth is a relative not a resource. In 2015 she joined the ancestors. Betty Hill (Lyons) and Tonya Gonnella Frichner, "Rights of Mother Earth," NGO, *American Indian Law Alliance*, March 18, 2018, <https://aila.ngo/issues/rights-mother-earth/>.

⁷ This JCRT double issue serves as the semicolon not the period to a longer conversation we have been having in person, on podcasts, and in print. For added context please see *CrossCurrents* Volume 74, Number 4, December 2024, *JCREOR* Volume 5 Number 2; and began with a wonderful series with the *Canopy Forum*. Cf. Philip P. Arnold, Sandy Bigtree, and Adam DJ Brett, eds., "200 Years of *Johnson v. M'Intosh*: Indigenous Responses to the Religious Foundations of Racism," special issue of *CrossCurrents* 74, no. 4 (December 2024), <https://muse.jhu.edu/pub/12/issue/55074>; Philip P. Arnold, Sandra Bigtree, and Adam DJ Brett, eds., "From Indigenous Religions to Indigenous Values," special issue of *Journal of the Council for Research on Religion (JCREOR)* 5, no. 2 (2024), <https://creor-ejournal.library.mcgill.ca/issue/view/12>; and the posts that began the it all "200 Years of *Johnson v. M'Intosh*: Law, Religion, and Native American Lands," thematic series, *Canopy Forum* (March–April 2023), produced in partnership with the Indigenous Values Initiative and Syracuse University, <https://canopyforum.org/200-years-of-johnson-v-mintosh-law-religion-and-native-american-lands/>.

only our culture and politics but also our language and, of course, also our pedagogy.⁸ We are thankful to the *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* (JCRT) and the editors, Carl Raschke and Victor Taylor, for providing a home for this critical double issue. Publishing these two issues with JCRT, we see as a continuation of the decades-long conversation on postcolonialism and decoloniality, which has been taking place in the pages of JCRT and its sibling publication, *The New Polis - A Journal of Critical Theory, Social Analysis, and Political Philosophy and Theology*. In the winter of 2014, JCRT published a special issue titled "Decoloniality and Crisis," and in Spring 2022, there was a special issue on the life and work of Charles H. Long, whose scholarship and legacy are seen throughout this volume; in fact, Philip P. Arnold was a contributor.⁹ In many ways, our double issue continues the conversation that Victor Taylor and Arnold had on his book *The Urgency of Indigenous Values* and Carl Raschke's critiques of religious studies¹⁰. In this first issue, you, the authors, are challenging hegemonic systems of eurochristianity and Hindutva, among others. Likewise, our contributors are approaching from different vantage points the questions of the inaugural issue of *The New Polis* journal, in Winter 2022, *Decoloniality and the Disintegration of Western Cognitive Empire*.¹¹

One of the conversations from earlier JCRT and TNP issues that continues here is the urgent need to interrogate and examine the metaphysics and ontologies of

⁸ *The Doctrine of Discovery: Unmasking the Domination Code*, Documentary, produced by Steven T. Newcomb and Sheldon P. Wolfchild, directed by Sheldon P. Wolfchild (38 Plus 2 Productions, 2015), Streaming, 01:02:04, <https://vimeo.com/ondemand/dominationcode>.

⁹ Philip P. Arnold, "Why the White Guy," *Journal of Cultural and Religious Theory* 21, no. 2 (2022): 170–73; Enrique D. Dussel, "Anti-Cartesian Meditations: On the Origin on the Philosophical Anti-Discourse of Modernity," *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* 13, no. 1 (2014), Atla Religion Database with AtlaSerials (ATLA0001969306), <https://research-ebsco-com.libezproxy2.syr.edu/linkprocessor/plink?id=ff574fc0-53e5-30e3-be99-84b649fc0b07>; Jordan E. Miller, "The Darker Side of Western Modernity: Global Futures, Decolonial Options," *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* (Durham) 13, no. 1 (2014), Atla Religion Database with AtlaSerials (ATLA0001969490), <https://research-ebsco-com.libezproxy2.syr.edu/linkprocessor/plink?id=f9ea57e9-0020-3c88-94e5-b1a75c7328d4>; George Schmidt, "Decolonizing Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples," *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* (New York) 13, no. 1 (2014), Atla Religion Database with AtlaSerials (ATLA0001969491), <https://research-ebsco-com.libezproxy2.syr.edu/linkprocessor/plink?id=c7504195-3bee-3c83-8b51-6ee7ba341a36>.

¹⁰ Philip P. Arnold and Victor E. Taylor, "A Conversation on the Urgency of Indigenous Values," *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* 23, no. 2 (2025): 132–39, Atla Religion Database with AtlaSerials (ATLAiXSE250531001694); Carl Raschke, "Religious Studies as the 'State Religion' of Neoliberalism," *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* 21, no. 3 (2022): 329–47, Atla Religion Database with AtlaSerials (ATLAi5J2221216001517).

¹¹ Cf. Catherine Walsh et al., "Decoloniality And Disintegration of Western Cognitive Empire – Rethinking Sovereignty and Territoriality In The 21st Century: WHAT DO WE MEAN BY 'DECOLONIALITY'?", *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* 20, no. 3 (2021): 341–60, Atla Religion Database with AtlaSerials (ATLAn5046507).

colonization. Here, reading Magna Mohapatra and Zunayed Ahmed Ehsan's earlier contribution "Reconstructing Diversal Ontologies: Unlearning as Decolonial Living" alongside this issue will prove illuminating. For Mohapatra and Eshan, colonialism has become so thoroughly imbricated in global knowledge systems that reality, and we would add metaphysics, are consistently interpreted through a eurochristian lens and a Euro-American framework. The authors trace the legacy of this colonial mindset back to European constructions of modernity, rationality, and progress, which, through over five hundred years of colonialism, became absorbed and naturalized as the normative and formative norms of society.¹² As historians of religion and students of Long's oeuvre, we understand the powerful mythic pull of ontologies of domination.¹³ Mohapatra and Ehsan call for an intentional process of unlearning hegemonic colonial epistemologies and rediscovering Indigenous ontologies and practices, much as Arnold, in agreement with Faithkeeper Lyons, calls for a value shift for survival.

Simultaneously however, Euro-American political and intellectual traditions, including the Enlightenment, were influenced by the Indigenous traditions of the Americas. Recent scholarship has been inspired by Graeber and Wengrow's "The Dawn of Everything," which traces many of these relationships.¹⁴ The indigenous nations in direct contact with European colonists during the 17th and 18th centuries were "under the wing" of the Haudenosaunee's Great Binding Peace.

Leading postcolonial and decolonial thinkers Walter Mignolo and Tink Tinker (Wazhazhe, Osage Nation), Catherine Walsh, and Fernando Herrero discuss what exactly scholars mean when they call for decoloniality.¹⁵ They emphasize that decoloniality must be grounded in a theoretical line and a lived praxis that begins with 1492. Alongside Newcomb, we would push for grounding decoloniality in the moments before arrival

¹² Magna Mohapatra, *Reconstructing Diversal Ontologies*, 1, no. 1 (2022), <https://journal.thenewpolis.com/archives/1.1/Mohapatra-Ehsan.pdf>.

¹³ Charles H Long, *Significations: Signs, Symbols, and Images in the Interpretation of Religion* (Fortress Press, 1986).

¹⁴ Graeber and Wengrow, *The Dawn of Everything, A New History of Humanity* (Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2021)

¹⁵ Walsh et al., "Decoloniality And Disintegration of Western Cognitive Empire – Rethinking Sovereignty and Territoriality In The 21st Century: WHAT DO WE MEAN BY 'DECOLONIALITY'?"

and take a view from the shore.¹⁶ In agreement with Mignolo, that decoloniality is grounded in Indigenous values and in what Newcomb describes as the original free, prior existence of Indigenous nations and peoples. Thinking 1491 means recognizing the pluriverse of Indigenous knowledges that existed and still exist; by drawing on these sources, we can begin dismantling the domination code and framework, revealing what is at work on the other side. These are a few of the generative connections that can be made reading not only the double issues *Justifications of Domination through Religion: "We were planting corn, and they were planting crosses"* and *"Challenging the Justifications of Domination through Law: Indigenous Resistance and the Undoing of Christian Empire"* but also the rest of *JCRT* and *TNP*.

#LANDBACK as a Healing Ceremony

As we continue to sit with this moment of encounter, we ask What is sacred? When we look at the Doctrine of Discovery and the Age of Colonization, one of the many themes that emerges is that the most sacred thing is the principle of ownership, especially of property. When asked to distill the Doctrine of Discovery down to its bare essence, Newcomb refers to the three e's: enslavement, exploitation, and extraction.¹⁷ Each of these three elements of the domination code is justified through theological and jurisprudential appeals to the proper transmission of a genealogy of domination. Within the domination code for the eurochristian colonizer, ownership and private property emerge as the most sacred things. There are a few appeals to scripture within the papal bulls and colonial charters which comprise the Doctrine of Discovery; likewise, there are few appeals to a shared humanity or the idea of the *imago dei* (image of God), and when it does appear with theologians and colonizers like Bartolomé de las Casas, it is fraught.¹⁸

¹⁶ Newcomb, "The Challenges of Revoking the Papal Bulls: A View-from-the-Shore Analysis of Recent Statements by Christian Churches."

¹⁷ Steven T Newcomb, *Pagans In The Promised Land: Decoding The Doctrine Of Christian Discovery* (Fulcrum Publishing, 2008); *Unmasking the Domination Code*.

¹⁸ Bartolomé de las Casas was willing to see the humanity of the Indigenous peoples of Turtle Island/Abya Yala but not the Indigenous peoples of Africa, until almost the end of his life. Tinker rightly cautions against seeing de las Casas as a hero or an abolitionist and questions the sincerity of the later day quest for redemption that de las Casas might have had Sheila M. Contreras, "The Spanish-Indigenous Binary and Anti-Blackness as Literary Inheritance," in *Latinx Literature in Transition, 1848-1992*, ed. John

Nevertheless, what we see with de las Casas and the eurochristian encounter with the Taíno is that for the colonizer, ownership is the most sacred thing. Fast forward to *Johnson v. M'Intosh* (1823) and the decision by Chief Justice John Marshall, and what we see is a theological and jurisprudential justification for the ownership of private property. Through his own ritual of dispossession, Marshall makes private property into a metaphysical and mystical sacred thing. In a putatively Protestant country that prides itself on the separation of church and state and the demythologizing of the world through "myth busting," one of the most sacrosanct elements is private property. Look at the language used to legitimize the racialized extrajudicial violence by landholders as "para-agents" of the state through the Castle Doctrine and "stand your ground" ground laws.¹⁹

Natalie Avalos, in her forthcoming book, elucidates the metaphysical fields of power that undergird these two value systems. The eurochristian metaphysic is rooted in domination and a *Deus Otiosus* on the one hand, and the Indigenous understanding of the metaphysical power of the land itself on the other. Thus, the intrinsic sacrality of the land means that all living beings live in a right, reciprocal relationship with the land, and that all living beings become an inherent obligation.²⁰ Faithkeeper Oren Lyons offers us the opportunity to consider the metaphysical and epistemological reconfiguration of ethics from an Indigenous perspective as a new natural law.²¹ Within the Indigenous worldviews discussed by our authors, we see that honoring Indigenous sovereignty is not only about affirming the original free, prior existence of Indigenous

Alba Cutler and Marissa López, vol. 2 (Cambridge University Press, 2025), Cambridge Core, <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009314206.009>; George E. Tinker, *American Indian Liberation: A Theology of Sovereignty* (Orbis Books, 2020); Manuel Méndez Alonzo, "From Slave Driver to Abolitionist: Bartolomé de Las Casas on African Slavery," *Patristica Et Mediaevalia* 36 (2015); Daniel José Camacho, "Unlearning the Doctrine of Discovery," *Sojourners*, October 8, 2018, <https://sojo.net/articles/opinion/unlearning-doctrine-discovery>; Lawrence Clayton, "Bartolomé de Las Casas and the African Slave Trade," *History Compass* 7, no. 6 (2009): 1526–41, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1478-0542.2009.00639.x>.

¹⁹ Abigail Cary Moore, "Stand Your Ground: Protecting Para-Agents of the Racial State," *Sociology of Race and Ethnicity*, SAGE Publications Sage CA: Los Angeles, CA, 2025, 23326492251375040; Biko Mandela Gray, *Black Life Matter: Blackness, Religion, and the Subject* (Duke University Press, 2022), 75–84; Kelly Douglas Brown, *Stand Your Ground: Black Bodies and the Justice of God* (Orbis Books, 2015); Bryan J McCann, "On Whose Ground? Racialized Violence and the Prerogative of 'Self-Defense' in the Trayvon Martin Case," *Western Journal of Communication* 78, no. 4 (2014): 480–99.

²⁰ Natalie Avalos and Eva Seligman, "Interdependence and Healing: Natalie Avalos on Practice, Scholarship, and the Liberating Power of Ceremony," *Insight Journal by Barre Center for Buddhist Studies* 48 (2022): 15–27.

²¹ Oren Lyons, "'Sovereignty and the Natural World Economy' as Part of 'the Current Picture: Progress or Impasse?,'" in *Justice for Natives*, ed. Andrea P. Morrison and Irwin Cotler, Searching for Common Ground (McGill-Queen's University Press, 1997), JSTOR, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt7zn4m.13>; Bill Moyers, *Oren Lyons-The Faithkeeper*, Moyers, 1991.

peoples but also about environmental care. Just as the colonizers brought ceremonies for dispossession, we are reminded by Vine Deloria Jr. (Lakota) that what we need today are ceremonies for healing the land and healing the relationships between humans, the land, and all living beings.²² From a Haudenosaunee perspective, there are many examples of what these ceremonies could look like, for example, starting each day with the *Ganoñhéñ•nyoñ'* (Thanksgiving Address or the Words that Come before All Else).²³ Another element is honoring treaties, such as the Haudenosaunee treaty with the Dutch, *Gaswéñdah*, and the Two Row Wampum Treaty. This treaty is still in effect and invites Indigenous peoples in their canoes and Europeans in their boats to live in balance and harmony with the natural world, without interfering in one another's affairs. Likewise, for settlers and arrivants living on Haudenosaunee territory, there is the Edge of the Woods Ceremony, which welcomes guests and visitors to these lands.²⁴

A contemporary and vital ceremony for healing the relationship with the land is the #Landback movement, and within the Onondaga Nation territory, the #Lakeback movement.²⁵ The American Indian Law Alliance along with their allies like the Neighbors of Onondaga Nation (NOON) and the Syracuse DSA launched the Return Maple Bay ~ Restore Our Sacred Onondaga Lake (#Lakeback) campaign as a way to honor the return of the Eagles to Onondaga Lake and to call for the healing of the reciprocal relationship between the Onondaga Lake, Onondaga Nation, and all living

²² *In the Light of Reverence*, with Christopher McLeod et al. (Bullfrog Films, 2010), 1 videodisc (74 min.): sound, color; 4 3/4 in., WorldCat, <http://docuseek2.com/v/a/zjD/1/0/0..>

²³ Haudenosaunee, "Haudenosaunee Thanksgiving Address Greetings to the Natural World," Smithsonian Institute, *American Indian Responses to Environmental Challenges*, n.d., accessed June 4, 2024, https://americanindian.si.edu/environment/pdf/01_02_Thanksgiving_Address.pdf; Philip P Arnold, "Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Thanksgiving and Private Property in Upstate New York," in *Sekaino Minshu Shukyo (Folk Religions of the World)*, by Michio Araki (Minerva Publishing Company, 2004).

²⁴ We are thankful to Sarah Nahar for introducing us to the work of poet Kamau Braithwaite's terms arrivant and arrivancy and Jodi Byrd's theorization of these terms within anticolonial and decolonial thinking (c.f. Nahar's contribution to this volume, "Using The Doctrine Of Discovery To Increase Shared Language And Conceptual Frameworks Between Black And Indigenous Feminist Organizing"). Cf. Jodi A Byrd, "Weather with You: Settler Colonialism, Antiracism, and the Grounded Relationalities of Resistance," *Critical Ethnic Studies* 5, nos. 1-2 (2019): 207-14..

²⁵ Nazune Menka, "The Landback Movement: Native Nations and the Restoration of Ancestral Lands," *Nat. Resources & Env't* 39, no. Winter (2024), https://www.americanbar.org/groups/environment_energy_resources/resources/natural-resources-environment/2025-winter/native-nations-restoration-ancestral-lands/; Mel Neal, "Between A Rock and A Hard Place: The Current Situation of The# Landback Movement and Indigenous-Imagined Futures," *Arizona Journal of Environmental Law & Policy* 13, no. 1 (2022): 47-72.. For more on the lake back movement visit lakeback.org.

beings.²⁶ In 2012, #IdleNoMore reminded the world that "Indigenous ways of knowing are rooted in Indigenous sovereignty to protect water, air, land, and all creation for future generations."²⁷ Learning from Indigenous values and Traditional Ecological Knowledge (TEK) means honoring treaties and returning Indigenous lands to Indigenous hands. Honoring Indigenous sovereignty is a form of environmental ethics and care. Onondaga Elder and Traditional Medicine Keeper teaches sovereignty, and the original free prior existence of Indigenous peoples is vital to understanding Haudenosaunee ecological knowledge.²⁸ Our dear friend, now ancestor, Tupac Enrique Acosta (Izkaloteka Mexica Azteca) reminds us of the importance of honoring the Territorial Integrity of Mother Earth while respecting the intrinsic sacrality of the land and the natural law of right relationship to the natural world and all living beings.²⁹ Returning to this relationship of care and mutual understanding has an urgency: as Faithkeeper Oren Lyons reminds us, "The ice is melting in the north."³⁰ As the ice melts, Indigenous nations and peoples continue to face the existential threats of exploitation and extraction in the name of technological advancement, whether that is rare earth minerals being extracted, data centers using up water, or nuclear waste being dumped into the drinking water, to name a few.³¹ We need what Faithkeeper Oren Lyons calls a value change for survival.³² This value change requires rethinking our philosophies, epistemologies, metaphysics, relationships, and more. In short, everything must change. Liberation from the eurochristian systems of domination requires addressing not only

²⁶ Adam DJ Brett and Betty Hill (Lyons), "Healing the Sacred: The Fight to Restore Onondaga Lake and Honor Indigenous Land," *International Journal on Responsibility* 9, no. 1 (2026): Article 2, <https://doi.org/10.62365/2576-0955.1133>.

²⁷ Kim TallBear, "Badass (Indigenous) Women Caretake Relations: #NoDAPL, #IdleNoMore, #BlackLivesMatter," *Cultural Anthropology* 22 (2016), <https://www.culanth.org/fieldsights/badass-indigenous-women-caretake-relations-no-dapl-idle-no-more-black-lives-matter>; Jessica M Dolan, *The Restorative Ecology of Peace: Haudenosaunee Environmental Knowledge and Philosophies of Stewardship* (McGill University (Canada), 2016).

²⁸ Dolan, *The Restorative Ecology of Peace: Haudenosaunee Environmental Knowledge and Philosophies of Stewardship*.

²⁹ Tupac Enrique Acosta, "Superseding the Doctrine of Discovery: World Water One," *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, March 29, 2023, <https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/blog/1CEMANAHUAC/>.

³⁰ Oren Lyons, "The Ice Is Melting in the North," *Manoa* 19, no. 2 (2007): 1–3.

³¹ Sarah Mangelsdorf and Lauren Behan, "Born Electric, Buried Toxic: The Life Cycle of Generative AI and Its Environmental Impact," *Brief* 54, no. 4 (2025); Obasesam Okoi, *Artificial Intelligence, the Environment and Resource Conflict: Emerging Challenges in Global Governance*, 2025; Matthew Bell, "The Cobalt Mines of the Democratic Republic of Congo," *Global Encounters: New Visions Department of Geography and Planning, Queen's University* 24 (2024).

³² Arnold, *The Urgency of Indigenous Values*; Oren Lyons, "Value Change For Survival," *American Indian Institute*, 2020, American Indian Law Alliance, https://aila.ngo/wp-content/uploads/2023/02/Value_Change_for_Survival.pdf.

these theological and cognitive frameworks but also the quotidian frameworks of culture, society, and economy. We are calling for a symbolic and material reorientation of life itself back towards planetary healing and flourishing, rooted in Indigenous values.³³

International Religious Nationalism and Domination

The roots of such systemic religious nationalism and domination that are so foundational to current international frameworks can be found in the crusades and even before that in the concept of Christendom itself.³⁴ Tracing the origins leads us to Maeve Callan's contribution, "The Medieval Origins of Religious White Supremacy: English Imperialism, Crusade Defeats, and the Doctrine of Discovery." She explores how medieval Christian ideologies influenced modern racism, imperialism, and white supremacy systems. Callan traces these origins to the Crusades and the ideology developed after military defeats in the Holy Land, when Christian powers sought new ways to justify violence and conquest. The article argues that the medieval Christian doctrine, especially concepts like Christendom versus infidel, laid the groundwork for later legal and theological rationales used to subjugate non-Christian peoples. After the Crusader losses, Western Christian states focused their religious aggression westward and northward, targeting Jews, Muslims, and especially Indigenous Europeans, such as the Irish and Baltic peoples. These campaigns established patterns of dehumanization, religious violence, and land seizure that prefigured colonial expansion.

Callan details how the English refined a model of imperial domination in Ireland that would influence their later colonial practices in the Americas. The laws, language, and

³³ "S05E07: Indigenous Wisdom for Planetary Healing with Yuria Celidwen," *Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery*, with Philip P. Arnold and Sandra Bigtree, March 26, 2025, <https://podcast.doctrineofdiscovery.org/season5/episode-07/>; Yuria Celidwen, *Flourishing Kin: Indigenous Wisdom for Collective Well-Being* (St. Martin's Essentials, 2024).

³⁴ Adam DJ Brett and Betty Hill (Lyons), "Documenting Domination: From the Doctrine of Christian Discovery to Dominion Theology," *Religions* 15, no. 12 (2024), <https://doi.org/10.3390/rel15121493>; Adam DJ Brett and Betty Hill, "Documenting Domination in International Relations Through the Doctrine of Discovery," *Cross Currents* (New York) 74, no. 4 (2024): 519–36, ProQuest Central (3223969514).. Newcomb and d'Errico are working on tracing domination all the way back to the ecumenical councils on their new educational podcast *Domination Chronicles*, you can follow along at www.dominationchronicles.com

violence used to mark religious and racialized differences emerged during these medieval conflicts, blending religious antagonism with proto-racial ideologies.

As the Doctrine of Discovery took shape in the fifteenth century, it drew upon these medieval precedents to legitimize Christian, and ultimately white, supremacy over Indigenous peoples worldwide. Callan contends that dismantling contemporary white supremacy and colonial structures requires recognizing and confronting their deep medieval religious roots.

Drawing upon Callan's analysis of the deep-rooted connections between medieval Christian doctrines and modern systems of supremacy, Nahar extends the conversation by demonstrating how these enduring frameworks of domination intersect with and inform Black feminist theory and the ongoing struggles for solidarity and liberation among marginalized communities. She advocates for integrating an analysis of settler colonialism into Black feminist theory to foster more robust solidarity and shared frameworks between Black and Indigenous feminist organizing. Nahar traces the historical overlap of Black and Indigenous oppression on Turtle Island (North America), focusing on how both groups experienced exploitation, erasure, and violence through settler colonialism – a system rooted in the Doctrine of Discovery (DoD). This 15th-century set of papal bulls legitimized the invasion, enslavement, and dispossession of non-Christian peoples and continues to underpin legal and social structures of oppression today.

Referencing the Combahee River Collective's legacy and the 2022 AfroFeministFutures panel, Nahar highlights ongoing gaps in Black feminist thought that have not been constantly explicitly confronted by settler colonialism or entirely centered on Indigenous women and their theorizing. She offers five reasons why Black feminism should incorporate settler colonial analysis: to prevent further harm, to acknowledge Black positionality within empire, to support Black-Indigenous people, to address antiblackness in Indigenous communities, and to acknowledge how settler colonialism impacts Black women. By engaging with the Doctrine of Discovery, Nahar suggests Black feminists can deepen their critique, connect struggles for liberation, and

advance collective freedom. She ultimately calls for collaborative visioning, ceremonies, and revised language that bridges past and future, forging more effective, relational Black and Indigenous feminist alliances.³⁵

While Nahar exposes the intertwined legacies of anti-Blackness and settler colonial structures, Wendy Felese provides a focused critique of how these same colonial and religious narratives resurface within current legal and social battles over land and sovereignty in the American West. Together, their approaches illuminate both the historical depth and the present-day consequences of domination, bridging theoretical insights with the lived realities of Indigenous land dispossession and ongoing resistance. Her article "The Chosen People at Grouse Mountain" critically examines ongoing land disputes in the American West, focusing on the 2018 'New Code of the West' conference at Grouse Mountain Lodge, Montana – a region noteworthy for both natural beauty and its ties to white nationalist movements. She explores how groups like the Citizens Equal Rights Alliance (CERA) employ populist rhetoric about government overreach yet are driven by concrete goals: redistribution of federal and Indigenous lands to private, often non-Native, interests. She analyzes these disputes through a cognitive-theoretical lens, arguing that both public land advocates and private stakeholders are shaped by an Idealized Cognitive Model (ICM) – what Steven Newcomb calls the "Chosen People – Promised Land" metaphor, originating from Eurochristian religious narratives. This metaphor frames settlers as divinely entitled to the land, rendering Indigenous claims invisible within legal and cultural debates structured around 'rights' discourse.

Tracing the lineage from biblical notions, papal bulls, and Locke's property theory to modern law, Felese demonstrates how federal Indian law and land policy

³⁵ Cf. Sarah Elizabeth Nahar, "Religious Moral Suasion and Material Support for the Environmental Justice Movement" *International Journal on Responsibility* 9, no. 1 (2026): Article 1, <https://doi.org/10.62365/2576-0955.1129>; Sarah Nahar, "Part 4: Making Common Cause: Imagining Shared Futures," Blog, *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, May 11, 2023, <https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/blog/river/imagining-shared-futures/>; Sarah Nahar, "Part 3: Using the Doctrine of Discovery to Foreground an Analysis of Settler Colonialism," Blog, *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, May 10, 2023, <https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/blog/river/settler-colonialism-analyzed/>; Sarah Nahar, "Part 2: The Beginning of an Analysis of Settler Colonialism Emerges at AMC 2022," Blog, *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, May 9, 2023, <https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/blog/river/beginning-analysis-settler-colonialism/>; Sarah Nahar, "Part 1: The Origins of the Combahee River Collective Statement," Blog, *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, May 8, 2023, <https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/blog/river/combahee-river/>.

remain deeply infused with religiously rooted concepts of natural law and possessive individualism. She calls for dismantling these dominant worldviews and replacing them with Indigenous frameworks grounded in respect, relationality, and reciprocity – arguing that only such a reorientation can address centuries of land dispossession and do justice to Native nations.

Continuing the focus on Christian domination through law, Telma Alencar's article explores the enduring effects and silencing of the Doctrine of Discovery in Brazil, illustrating how colonial and religious legacies underpin the country's ongoing social inequalities and violence against Indigenous peoples. The Doctrine, originating in a series of 15th-century papal bulls, justified colonization, exploitation, and slavery of non-Christian peoples under the myth of *Terra Nullius* ("empty land"). Alencar demonstrates how these ideas shaped Portuguese colonization of Brazil, legitimizing the violent dispossession and marginalization of Indigenous communities. She critiques the perpetuation of these myths in Brazilian education and historiography, sustained by elite interests, with specific attention to the role of Christian institutions – particularly the Catholic Church and Jesuit missions – in sanctioning land seizure and forced labor.

Alencar details how official narratives obscured planned colonial invasions and covers up archival evidence, such as the *Esmeraldo de Situ Orbis* manuscripts, which showed foreknowledge of Brazil's land and riches. She links the Doctrine's ongoing legacy to modern forms of neocolonialism, including environmental exploitation and U.S. interventions like the 1964 military coup and educational reforms that further entrenched Eurocentric, market-driven ideologies.

Ultimately, Alencar calls for decolonizing Brazilian history and education, recognizing Indigenous rights, and challenging the systemic structures that silence historical violence. Addressing the Doctrine's legacy is, she argues, essential for understanding and dismantling contemporary inequalities, forging paths toward justice, Indigenous sovereignty, and true societal inclusivity.

Keeping with the international focus "Baltic Religion: The Sacred Things" by Eglutė Trinkauskaitė and Ellen B. Cutler explores the core elements and rituals of traditional Baltic religious beliefs before and after Christianization. The article centers

on the sacredness of landscape, objects, and the cyclical rhythms that governed daily and ritual life in Baltic communities, reflecting a cosmology deeply rooted in reverence for nature and ancestral spirits. Ultimately, for Trinkauskaitė and Culter, the Baltic religious worldview, centered on respect, ritual care, and the sanctity of natural things, persists in various forms, testifying to the resilience of Indigenous spiritualities despite outside pressures and theological transformation.

While Trinkauskaitė and Cutler illuminate the resilience of Indigenous Baltic spirituality, tracing how respect for land and ritual persists despite centuries of Christianization, the conversation turns next to another site of marginalization and survival: the lived religion of Dalit women in India. Shrutika Lakshmi's essay, "Other Forms of Dwelling: A Dalit-Feminist Perspective," moves us from the landscapes of Northern Europe to the social margins of South Asia, where mainstream religious categories prove inadequate for capturing the lived realities and agency of those most affected by entrenched caste and gender hierarchies. In both contexts, we see how Indigenous and marginalized communities craft alternative forms of meaning, kinship, and relationship to the sacred—challenging the dominance of imposed theological frameworks and revealing the power of values and practices rooted in resistance and survival. Drawing on Philip P. Arnold's book, Lakshmi argues that mainstream religious frameworks not only fail to capture the values of marginalized groups but have historically served to uphold systems of power and subjugation—particularly through caste and gender hierarchies. Dalit women, located at the intersection of caste and gender oppression, have long been rendered invisible within academic and activist discourses.

Building on Lakshmi's exploration of how dominant religious frameworks support and sustain systems of marginalization, Pranay Somayajula's essay turns our focus to the political theology underpinning Hindutva. While Lakshmi centers the embodied, lived experiences of Dalit women who resist both Brahmanical Hindu and colonial Christian domination, Somayajula interrogates how Hindutva constructs a singular, exclusionary Hindu identity through political and theological means. This shift in perspective further deepens our understanding of how religion, power, and identity are mobilized both to oppress and to resist, highlighting the complex negotiations at play within South Asian contexts. Somayajula's essay "Hindu Political Theology: Beyond Hindutva's Political Monotheism" examines the ideological development of Hindutva, or Hindu nationalism, through the lens of political theology, particularly following Carl Schmitt's framework. The paper contends that Hindutva

constructs a singular, unitary Hindu identity – framed not just in religious terms, but also racial and civilizational ones – by flattening the immense diversity of beliefs and practices under the Hindu umbrella. This project, described by scholars like Anustup Basu as a form of “political monotheism,” attempts to forge national unity by erasing regional, linguistic, caste, and gender pluralities, positioning the Hindu nation as inherently indigenous and non-Hindus as outsiders.

The essay ultimately argues for resistance against Hindutva’s restrictive political theology by embracing the syncretic, pluralistic, and inclusive traditions inherent in Hinduism and Indian identity. Decoupling Hindu-ness from nationalist ideology is essential, Somayajula asserts, to prevent the erasure of India’s diverse cultural fabric and to safeguard democracy and minority rights.

Concluding the international focus, Adam DJ Brett and Betty Hill (Lyons) reflect on the enduring impact of the Doctrine of Christian Discovery, as crystallized in the 1823 Supreme Court case *Johnson v. M’Intosh*. They argue that the doctrine’s religious framework provided the legal, moral, and theological justification for white supremacy, dispossession, and violence against Indigenous peoples in America. Their piece calls attention to how this precedent continues to shape policies and narratives, perpetuating the marginalization of Native nations and their sovereignty. The authors emphasize that confronting white supremacy requires not only legal reform but also a reckoning with the religious roots of these structures. They advocate for increased education, alliance-building, and collective action to dismantle the Doctrine of Discovery’s legacy.

Teaching Against Racism and Hegemony

Having established a foundation for understanding how Euro-Christian frameworks of domination operate through their theological, jurisprudential, and ritual doctrines, the volume moves to a more in-depth reflection on systems of domination. While examining systems of domination and hegemony within religious studies and critical Christian studies is important to us, we also want to consider the broader intellectual and disciplinary conversations happening within studies of religious nationalism, such as those around Hindu nationalism. Finally, one of the ongoing critiques and concerns we have heard at our Doctrine of Discovery conferences over the years is, “Yah, this is all great, but how do I teach it?” We take these concerns about pedagogy seriously, which is why we have produced two podcasts: *The Doctrine of*

Christian Discovery, a limited series, and Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery, now entering its sixth season and ongoing.

Likewise, when our dear friend, colleague, and Phil's former student Michael E. Chaness, wanted to create a panel on anti-racist pedagogy and teaching against religious hegemony, we were elated. Transitioning to discussions of educational practice, this journal issue shifts from the theoretical and historical analysis to the concrete impacts of these frameworks on knowledge production and pedagogy. The previous essays' insights on the theological, legal, ritual, and legal underpinnings of domination serve as a vital background for the pedagogical reflections that follow, linking the metaphysical framework of domination directly to the lived relationships and responsibilities of educators. It is in this context that reflective essays from Michael E. Chaness, Ritu Radhakrishnan, Celina Duran Jimenez, Danielle S. Nagle, and Renée Barry illuminate how domination, white supremacy, and colonial logics persist in curricula, campus environments, and heritage narratives. Each author's contribution demonstrates – through case studies and personal narratives – how these forces are embedded in the structures and stories of academic institutions and public memory, thus weaving together the essay's macro-historical analysis with the micro-level experiences of teaching and learning today.

In his essay "Expecting Excellence in Education: When Content Conditions Class Consciousness," Chaness explores the intersection of white supremacy, settler colonialism, and educational practice through both personal reflection and academic analysis. He recounts his return to Syracuse University and involvement with a panel titled "Pupils in the Professed Land: Confronting White Supremacy Across the Disciplines," where interdisciplinary scholars discussed how their research and teaching challenge systemic oppression. Reflecting on his own career, Chaness highlights his work with the Onondaga Nation and the responsibilities of reciprocity and collaboration in Native American Studies at SUNY Oswego.

Chaness illustrates how historical patterns of settler colonialism and white supremacy are perpetuated through educational content and campus environments,

notably through naming practices that obscure or distort Haudenosaunee histories. Chaness draws on scholars such as Robin Kimmerer, John Mohawk, Audra Simpson, Laura Harjo, and Nick Estes to analyze settler colonialism's ongoing impact, particularly on Indigenous sovereignty and women. He also discusses the educational power of art, particularly Jim Denomie's painting, to illuminate these issues.

The essay culminates in a description of his campus administrative work, including a taskforce recommending the removal and replacement of Indigenous-themed campus names that lack educational context, and the establishment of programs centering Indigenous voices and histories. Chaness asserts that genuine progress requires systemic changes in university values and educational practices, advocating for collaborative approaches that recognize historical harms while centering Indigenous perspectives for a more just academic environment.

Building on the innovative pedagogy of Chaness at SUNY Oswego, Roberta Hurtado – also a faculty member at Oswego – brings a powerful personal and scholarly perspective to the teaching of literature, further enriching the department's commitment to diversity and critical engagement. In her article "Flesh of Words: Confrontation, Navigation, and Integrity in the English Classroom," Hurtado offers a deeply personal and academic reflection on her journey as a British and Puerto Rican professor of English. Hurtado's narrative highlights how intersectionality and subject position shape both the experience and teaching of literature. Drawing on frameworks from Latina Feminisms – particularly Gloria Anzaldúa and Cherríe Moraga's idea of "theory in the flesh" – Hurtado explores how lived experience influences classroom interactions, curriculum development, and student engagement. She shares her struggles navigating predominantly Anglo-academic spaces, her perseverance in seeking growth, and her feelings of isolation as one of the few Latina faculty members at her institution.

Hurtado highlights the importance of presenting literature by Latino authors, not as a token or an exception, but as standard and necessary. She details pedagogical approaches designed to foster critical engagement, especially among students

unfamiliar with non-Western literary frameworks. Hurtado stresses the value of self-reflection, ongoing learning, and humility for both educators and students. Integrating her own story with that of her students, she focuses on cultivating awareness, confronting discomfort, and resisting colonial legacies in education. Ultimately, Hurtado's work models academic integrity, resilience, and a commitment to social justice, advocating for literature classrooms that empower students to recognize diverse epistemologies and challenge exclusionary practices.

In dialogue with Hurtado's insights on critical pedagogy and intersectionality in the English classroom, her colleague at SUNY Oswego, Ritu Radhakrishnan, further expands these themes by examining how educational structures can either disrupt or reinforce white supremacy in teacher education and K-12 curricula. In her essay, "Schools, Teachers, and Teacher Educators: Education Through the Disruption of White Supremacy," Radhakrishnan asserts that education in the United States has historically played a role in upholding white supremacy through curricula, school policies, and teacher certification processes. Using personal experiences and scholarly research, Radhakrishnan describes how schools systematically assimilate students of color, erasing linguistic and cultural identities while normalizing whiteness. She explores the nature of explicit, implicit, and null curricula, arguing that unchallenged, these frameworks reinforce exclusionary practices and sustain social and racial hierarchies. Radhakrishnan advocates disrupting the status quo through culturally sustaining pedagogy, which celebrates pluralism and affirms the experiences of marginalized students. She highlights ongoing barriers faced by future teachers—especially those from BIPOC and lower-income backgrounds—due to certification requirements and professional expectations rooted in white, middle-class norms. While recognizing her own role in guiding teacher candidates through these systems, Radhakrishnan emphasizes that meaningful change requires uncovering truth, teaching hidden histories, and preparing educators to actively oppose white supremacy. Ultimately, she argues that although schools have served to reproduce and assimilate, the true aim of education should be liberation.

Continuing this critical dialogue at SUNY Oswego, Celinet Duran Jimenez expands the conversation by analyzing the pervasive effects of white supremacy within educational systems and emphasizing the necessity of systemic change in both curriculum and practice. In "Dismantling White Supremacy in the Classroom and Beyond," Duran Jimenez examines how white supremacy permeates educational systems and insists on the urgent need to challenge and reform these structures. Duran Jimenez emphasizes that white supremacy is the core of systemic oppression in education, shaping curricula, narratives, and institutional practices to the detriment of students of color and other marginalized identities. She discusses how these systems contribute to internalized racism, perpetuate stereotypes, and sustain inequality from K-12 through higher education.

Drawing from her experiences as an Afro-Latina, immigrant, and first-generation student, as well as her professional role as a criminal justice professor, Duran Jimenez details how these lived realities inform her pedagogy. She prioritizes inclusive, transparent, and collaborative teaching practices, uses open educational resources to reduce financial barriers, and designs courses that confront the historical roots and ongoing realities of oppression in the criminal justice system. Collaborating with colleagues and centering marginalized voices, she emphasizes the critical role that faculty play in challenging and transforming curricula dominated by white, Western perspectives.

Duran Jimenez concludes that confronting white supremacy in academia is both an ethical imperative and essential for creating equitable educational environments. She calls for collective, sustained action from educators, highlighting the powerful role of education in fostering critical consciousness and empowering students to resist and dismantle oppression.

Having surveyed innovative and critical pedagogical approaches, we now shift our attention from the immediate context of higher education to broader communal educational spaces within Central New York's wider landscape. As we consider how narratives of power and domination are constructed, maintained, or

resisted in classrooms, we must also examine how these same forces are inscribed upon the land itself. The Erie Canal, a defining feature of the region, offers a powerful case study of how infrastructure, public memory, and environmental transformation continue to shape and be shaped by the ongoing legacies of colonialism and dispossession. By moving from the pedagogical reflections at SUNY Oswego and Syracuse University to the historical and ecological complexities of the Erie Canal, we deepen our understanding of how educational, cultural, and territorial narratives intertwine, highlighting both challenges and possibilities for justice, reconciliation, and decolonial futures. Elainia Berlin, a former student of these professors and now a Ph.D. student herself, reflects on what she has learned from them and offers pedagogical reflections as a student turned colleague, and courageously provides recommendations for how scholars may improve their pedagogy.

Decolonial Pedagogy and the Erie Canal

In the essay "Engineering Marvel: Towards Resisting the Affective Politics of Erie Canal Heritage," Danielle S. Nagle interrogates the dominant narratives characterizing the Erie Canal as a symbol of American ingenuity and progress. Nagle, a white settler scholar, contends that the canal's celebrated status masks its violent origins—specifically, the dispossession of Haudenosaunee (Six Nations) lands through broken treaties and the legal power of the Doctrine of Christian Discovery. The article analyzes current marketing and commemorative frameworks, revealing how affective politics—emotions engineered through heritage tourism and branding—encourage celebration and nostalgia while suppressing the traumatic histories of Indigenous genocide, dispossession, and ecological disruption. Nagle explores how these narratives are reinforced through educational curricula, tourism materials, and public memory, shaping how both land and bodies are contested and controlled. She advocates for embodied, affective resistance: a practice of feeling and acknowledging these painful histories as a foundation for justice, truth-telling, and potential healing. For Nagle

argues that true justice must center Indigenous sovereignty and land return, going beyond performative inclusion toward genuine transformation.

This work is crucial for ecological study because it exposes how landscapes are not merely physical spaces but are continually shaped by political, historical, and affective forces. Understanding the Erie Canal's creation and ongoing legacy helps ecologists and environmental scholars recognize the deep interconnection between colonial violence, environmental disruption, and ongoing struggles for land, justice, and multispecies flourishing.

Nagle's friend and colleague Renée Barry, in "Deconstructing the Erie Canal: Three Lessons for its Next Century," uses auto-ethnography to critically examine herself and her relationship to the landscape and the dominant narratives and historical representations of the Erie Canal as it turns 200. Barry interrogates how the Canal's celebrated stories conceal colonial violence, dispossession, and environmental destruction. By unpacking the infrastructure's origins, Barry reveals that the Canal's construction relied on the erasure of Indigenous histories, land, and democratic systems, and was justified through Christian and white supremacist ideologies rooted in the Doctrine of Discovery.³⁶ The essay illustrates how these intertwined religious, racial, and economic logics continue to shape New York's self-understanding and environmental ambitions, as seen in modern initiatives like Reimagine the Canals. Barry links personal experiences and archival research to expose the ongoing impacts of these patterns, including the perpetuation of power hierarchies and the exclusion of Indigenous voices. She calls for a deeper reckoning with erased histories and lessons — warning against repeating old cycles in new projects and advocating for truth-telling, reconciliation, and recognition of Indigenous leadership in environmental stewardship.

This essay is vital for anti-colonial and decolonial thinking because it uncovers how infrastructure, memory, and narrative can perpetuate colonial relationships to land

³⁶ Indigenous Values Initiative, "What Is the Doctrine of Discovery?," Doctrine of Discovery Project, July 30, 2018, <https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/what-is-the-doctrine-of-discovery/>.

and people. By centering erased voices and questioning triumphalist histories, Barry's work fosters more just, truthful, and sustainable approaches to both education and environmental futures.

These pedagogical reflections are especially important for educators engaged in critical Indigenous studies, religious studies, and environmental studies. They challenge us to scrutinize not just the content of what we teach but the values and worldviews that inform our curricula, classroom practices, and institutional policies. By foregrounding Indigenous epistemologies and re-centering reciprocal relationships with land and community, educators can resist the reproduction of colonial habits of thought and create transformative spaces where students critically engage dominant narratives. This task is urgent: fostering critical consciousness in the next generation is essential for dismantling structures of domination and promoting more just, sustainable, and relational futures—in education and beyond. Only by grounding pedagogy in Indigenous values, and committing to ongoing self-examination and unlearning, can we begin to dismantle the framework of domination and work toward planetary healing and justice.³⁷

³⁷ Arnold, *The Urgency of Indigenous Values*.